CRISIS PLAYBOOK · NO. 02

- T+00:00 Incident declared
- T+00:02 Alert sent · push, SMS, voice
- T+01:30 Escalated · no response
- T+04:10 Team acknowledged



PROPERTY, HOUSING AND FACILITIES

Every resident reached.

Fire, flood, gas, a dead lift or a building system that stops obeying. A playbook for reaching every resident, occupier and member of staff in the first hour, including the people who cannot leave on their own.

T+00:00 · T+00:05 · T+00:15 · T+01:00 · T+04:00

INSIDE

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For landlords, managing agents and facilities teams: reach every resident in a building emergency, and prove afterwards that you did.

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FOREWORD

In a building emergency, the message is part of the safety system.

When something goes wrong in a block of flats, an office or a care setting, the physical response gets the attention: the fire service, the engineer, the shut-off valve. Yet the UK's Grenfell Tower Inquiry found that the people affected were also failed by information. The landlord's records of residents who might need help to escape were incomplete on the night, and afterwards the council had no effective way to communicate with those forced from their homes.[1]

The lesson travels. Fire and building codes differ between England, the United States, the European Union and the Gulf, and we set out the main duties region by region. Underneath them, the questions are the same everywhere: who is inside, who needs help to leave, how quickly they hear what to do, and whether anyone can show later what was decided and why.

There is a newer risk too. In 2026 attackers reached refrigeration controllers across Europe that had been left exposed to the internet, and US agencies warned that such access could change settings and create fire hazards.[2,3] A building system that is switched off, or quietly changed, is now a credible way for an emergency to begin. This playbook is for the people who own that first hour: housing and property managers, facilities and building safety leads, and the out-of-hours teams who pick up the phone at 3am. It is practical and vendor-neutral; our companion report sets out the evidence.

The Crises Control team
Crises Control

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Reach every resident in minutes, find who is missing, and keep the record.

01 · THE OPERATIONAL CHALLENGE

- Building emergencies start out of hours, in buildings where few staff are on site.
- Records of residents who need help are often incomplete, unconsented or out of reach at 3am.
- Contractors, building systems and housing teams each hold part of the picture, and nobody holds all of it.

02 · INCIDENTS AND RISKS TO PREPARE FOR

- Fire in a high-rise block, including a change from stay put to full evacuation.
- Flood, gas escape or power loss that disables lifts, door entry and medical equipment.
- A building management system fault or tampering that cuts heat, ventilation or access.
- One fault hitting several blocks at night, with residents displaced.

03 · KEY RECOMMENDATIONS

- Keep a consented assistance register, with contact channel and language, available out of hours.
- Approve messages for each emergency in advance, including the change to evacuation.
- Set escalation by severity and time so silence is chased, not assumed to be safety.
- Take building controls off the internet and agree remote access rules with contractors.
- Exercise a night-time, multi-building incident at least once a year.

04 · WHAT EFFECTIVE COORDINATION LOOKS LIKE

- One incident across all affected blocks, with one named lead and a severity level.
- Every flat marked reached, visited, passed to the fire service or confirmed away.
- Residents who need help contacted first, and their status reported to the incident commander.
- A timestamped log of messages, acknowledgements and decisions, ready for any review.

05 · HOW CRISES CONTROL SUPPORTS THE RESPONSE

Most organisations can send alerts. Few can manage incidents end-to-end.

Residents, staff and contractors can be alerted by push, SMS, voice and email, with acknowledgements tracked by the groups you set up for each block and floor.

Those who do not respond are re-alerted under the escalation rules you configure; tasks, decisions and messages are kept in one timestamped record.

INTRODUCTION

Three things decide whether everyone is reached.

Most organisations can send alerts. Few can manage incidents end-to-end. In a building emergency the gap shows in three places: who knows, how fast they hear, and whether anyone can show later what was decided and why.

Know who is in the building

A current, consented record of residents and occupiers who may need help, with how each prefers to be contacted and who can act for them.

Reach them in minutes, not hours

Pre-approved messages for each kind of emergency, sent on more than one channel, with a way to see who has not acknowledged.

Log every decision

A single, timestamped record of what was known, what was decided, who was told and when. It protects residents first and your organisation second.

A plan that cannot reach the person on the ninth floor is not a plan.

Evacuation strategies, contractor rotas and building alarms all depend on one thing working: getting the right instruction to the right person, knowing it arrived, and coordinating what happens next.

PART 01

Know your building.

Before the alarm sounds: the emergencies you will face, the duties that apply where you operate, and who inside needs help.

01 Why building emergencies are communication emergencies

02 Fire and evacuation duties, by region

03 Response clocks and resident communication, by region

04 Six emergencies, six first messages

05 A resident assistance register

KNOW YOUR BUILDING

Why building emergencies are communication emergencies

> **The physical emergency is only half of it. Who knows, how fast, and what they do next usually decides the harm.**

Every building emergency has two parts. One is physical: a fire, a burst main, a gas escape, a stuck lift, a power cut. The other is informational: who needs to know, what they should do, and whether they have understood.

The Grenfell Tower Inquiry in the UK is blunt on this. The landlord's emergency plan was out of date and incomplete, missing fire action notices were a prominent subject of residents' complaints, and its information on vulnerable residents was incomplete on the night.[1] Afterwards, the council had no arrangements for identifying those forced from their homes or for communicating with them.[1]

Residents notice when communication fails in ordinary times too. In its review of complaints determined in 2025-26, England's Housing Ombudsman found poor communication and inadequate record keeping running through its most serious repairs cases.[4]

The building itself is changing. Heating, ventilation, lifts, access and pumps are increasingly run from a building management system (BMS) that a contractor can reach remotely. In October 2026 France's CERT-FR reported numerous compromises of internet-exposed refrigeration controllers.[2] US agencies warned that such attacks could alter settings and create fire hazards.[3]

We found no public report of a residential BMS being compromised in that wave. But the controllers that run heating, ventilation and lifts are often reached remotely in the same way, and for elderly residents heating switched off on a winter night is a welfare emergency, whatever caused it.

So the planning question is not only how to fight a fire or fix a pipe. It is how quickly you can tell everyone what to do, and how you will know who has not heard.

REGIONAL NOTES

Fire and evacuation duties for residential buildings

Who must plan for evacuation, and what residents must be told, differs by country and often by city. The operational guidance in this playbook works under all of them.

REGIONAL NOTE · UNITED KINGDOM

England: responsible persons for blocks of flats give residents fire safety instructions every 12 months; in high-rise blocks, firefighting lift faults not fixed in 24 hours go to the fire service.[5] From 6 April 2026, taller blocks need evacuation plans for residents who cannot leave unaided.[6]

IN PRACTICE In higher-risk buildings, add the residents' engagement strategy and mandatory occurrence reporting.[7,8]

REGIONAL NOTE · EUROPEAN UNION

Building and fire safety rules are set nationally, often regionally. The Construction Products Regulation (EU) 2024/3110 harmonises how products are assessed, while requirements for buildings stay with member states.[12] Employers must arrange first aid, fire-fighting and evacuation of workers.[13]

IN PRACTICE Work from the national code and fire authority guidance in each country; one model rarely fits every border.

REGIONAL NOTE · UNITED STATES

No single national code for housing. NFPA 101, the Life Safety Code, is a model code that applies where a state or local jurisdiction has adopted it, often with amendments.[9] Where an OSHA standard requires one, employers need an emergency action plan that includes accounting for employees after evacuation.[10]

IN PRACTICE Check the edition your state or city has adopted. NFPA 1660 (2024) is a voluntary planning standard.[11]

REGIONAL NOTE · MIDDLE EAST (UAE, SAUDI ARABIA)

UAE: the UAE Fire and Life Safety Code of Practice, issued by Civil Defence, is the national fire code.[14]
Saudi Arabia: the Saudi Fire Protection Code, SBC 801 (2024), covers emergency planning, evacuation plans, drills and mass notification systems.[15]

IN PRACTICE In Dubai, owners must keep fire systems maintained and seek Civil Defence approval before changes that affect them.[16]

A summary for orientation, not legal advice. Requirements depend on sector, size, licence and jurisdiction, and change over time. Confirm the current text with your legal and compliance teams.

REGIONAL NOTES

Response clocks and resident communication

Some regimes put a clock on hazards in homes, or say who keeps occupants informed. Build these timings into your escalation rules.

REGIONAL NOTE · UNITED KINGDOM

England, social landlords: under Awaab's Law, emergency hazards must be investigated and made safe within 24 hours, with written findings and progress updates to tenants.[17] From 30 November 2026 the regime extends to fire, electrical, excess cold and other hazards.[18]

IN PRACTICE The clock starts when the landlord becomes aware, often through an out-of-hours call. Time-stamp every report.

REGIONAL NOTE · UNITED STATES

HUD-assisted housing: under HUD's inspection standards, a missing or non-working smoke alarm is a life-threatening deficiency with a 24-hour correction timeframe.[19] Workplace emergency action plans must be reviewed with each employee covered.[10]

IN PRACTICE State and city housing codes add their own timescales; record which apply to each building.

REGIONAL NOTE · EUROPEAN UNION

Member states must ensure official public warnings about major emergencies reach mobile users in the area.[20] These warnings come from the authorities and do not replace your own instructions to residents and staff.

IN PRACTICE Plan for residents receiving an official alert and your message at the same time. Keep them consistent.

REGIONAL NOTE · MIDDLE EAST (UAE, SAUDI ARABIA)

Dubai: facilities must have a designated, qualified person who implements preventive safety requirements, liaises with Civil Defence and keeps occupants informed.[16] **Saudi Arabia:** SBC 801 sets requirements for employee training and response procedures.[15]

IN PRACTICE Name that person in your plan and in the escalation workflow, with a deputy for nights.

A summary for orientation, not legal advice. Requirements depend on sector, size, licence and jurisdiction, and change over time. Confirm the current text with your legal and compliance teams.

SIX EMERGENCIES

Six emergencies, and what the first message must say

The first message sets the tone for everything after it. Agree the wording now, not on the night.

EMERGENCY	FIRST MESSAGE MUST SAY	WATCH FOR
Fire	Where it is, the current strategy and how to report a fire, matching the instructions residents already hold.	A change of strategy. The second message matters more than the first.
Flood or escape of water	Which floors are affected, whether to isolate electrics, where to go if homes are unsafe.	Water reaching risers, lift pits and electrical intakes.
Gas	No switches or flames, open windows, leave if told to, call the gas emergency number.	Residents who cannot leave quickly.
Lift failure	Which lifts are out, expected return, help for those who cannot use stairs.	Firefighting lifts. **UK:** in high-rise blocks, faults not fixed in 24 hours go to the fire service.[5]
Power failure	Scope, expected duration, what still works, welfare checks for powered medical equipment.	Door entry and warden call that depend on mains power.
BMS fault or tampering	What people will notice (heat, ventilation, access), what to report, and that the cause is being checked.	Settings that change back after a reset.

TEMPLATE

Resident assistance register

One row for each resident who may need help to leave or to stay safe at home. **UK:** in buildings in scope, offer a person-centred fire risk assessment, agree an emergency evacuation statement and review it every 12 months.[6]

BLOCK, FLOOR, FLAT	RESIDENT	HELP NEEDED	CONTACT CHANNEL AND LANGUAGE	CARER OR NAMED CONTACT	CONSENT TO SHARE WITH FIRE SERVICE	NEXT REVIEW
Block B, floor 9, flat 9.04	*Initials only*	*Wheelchair user; cannot use stairs. Evacuation plan agreed.*	*Voice call in Polish; SMS copy to daughter*	*Daughter, mobile on file*	*Yes, recorded 12 March 2026*	*March 2027*

Illustrative example row. Health details are sensitive: record only what an emergency needs, follow your data protection law and limit who can see the register. Add residents with powered medical equipment, hearing or sight loss, and those who do not read the local language, even where no evacuation plan is required. Keep a current copy available out of hours and away from the office.

PART 02

Incident scenarios.

When the alarm sounds: how serious it is, what the first hour looks like, and three nights that go wrong in different ways.

01 A severity ladder for buildings

02 Fire in a high-rise block at 02:10

03 Three blocks, one night

04 Three buildings, three bad nights

05 The morning after: what is still open

SEVERITY

A severity ladder for buildings

Agree the levels in advance so the person on call does not have to decide alone. Each level names who is alerted and how.

SEV 1 **Life at risk**	TRIGGERS Fire with smoke spreading, change from stay put to evacuation, gas escape inside the building, people trapped, structural movement, or any hazard your rules say must be made safe within 24 hours.	WHO IS ALERTED, HOW Duty manager, building safety lead, senior leadership, every affected resident, contractors and the fire service liaison. `Voice + SMS + push, repeat until acknowledged`
SEV 2 **Safety at risk**	TRIGGERS Firefighting or evacuation lift out with no fix in 24 hours, loss of heating in cold weather, flood affecting electrics, unexplained BMS changes.	WHO IS ALERTED, HOW Duty manager, building safety lead, contractor, residents of affected floors, welfare team for vulnerable residents. `SMS + push + email, voice for vulnerable residents`
SEV 3 **Service disruption**	TRIGGERS Single lift out with another working, planned shutdown overrun, door entry fault, local leak contained.	WHO IS ALERTED, HOW Duty manager, contractor, affected residents or occupiers. `SMS or push + email`
SEV 4 **Monitor**	TRIGGERS BMS alarm cleared, minor fault logged, advance notice of works.	WHO IS ALERTED, HOW Building team and contractor; residents only if they will notice. `Email or app notice`

WORST DAY

Fire in a high-rise block, 02:10 on a winter night

Illustrative: a 20-storey block with a stay-put strategy and residents who need help to leave. Adapt the roles to your structure.

CLOCK	ACTION	OWNER
T+00:00	**Fire reported, emergency services called** A resident calls the emergency services and the out-of-hours line. The incident is opened; duty manager and building safety lead alerted under the plan's escalation rules.	OUT-OF-HOURS
T+00:08	**First message to residents** Approved message to every resident: location, current strategy, how to report smoke. SMS, push and voice.	DUTY MANAGER
T+00:12	**Information for the fire service** Plans and on-site information box confirmed. Consented list of residents who need help ready for the incident commander.	BUILDING SAFETY LEAD
T+00:20	**Strategy change** If the fire service decides to evacuate, one message goes to all residents at once. Non-acknowledgements are chased.	DUTY MANAGER
T+00:30	**Vulnerable residents** Each resident on the register is reached, or reported to the incident commander as not reached.	WELFARE LEAD
T+00:45	**Contractors, holding line, log** Lift, alarm and BMS contractors called; no remote changes without approval. Holding statement issued. Log checked.	FACILITIES AND COMMS

MULTI-BUILDING SCENARIO

Three blocks, one night

Illustrative: at 01:40 a fault in a shared plant room cuts power to Blocks A, B and C on one estate. Smoke is reported in Block B's basement. Lifts and door entry stop in all three.

	01:40	01:50	02:05	02:20	02:45	03:30
Out-of-hours line	Calls arrive from all three blocks ! Logged as three separate repair jobs	Merged into one incident, duty manager alerted				
Duty manager (incident lead)		◆ Declares one SEV 1 incident across three blocks	◆ Approves block-specific messages	◆ Decides to open a rest centre	Live view of flats reached, by block	Hands over to the day team with the log
Residents, three blocks		! One message to all three blocks	Block B told to leave; A and C stay put	Acknowledgements tracked by block and flat	Updates every 30 minutes	
Welfare and caretaking			Calls assistance register, Block B first	! No power for medical equipment overnight	Door-knocks flats still silent	Every register resident's status confirmed
Contractors and fire service		Fire service attends; electrician called	◆ Incident commander evacuates Block B	! Contractor wants to reset plant controls	Settings recorded before any reset	Power back to A and C; B isolated

Action · Decision · Where it goes wrong · Monitored

> The red points are where nights like this usually fail: separate jobs instead of one incident, one message for three different situations, residents who depend on power, and evidence lost to a reset. Each has a named decision owner and a way of being monitored.

IN PRACTICE

Three buildings, three bad nights

SUPPORTED HOUSING, 40 FLATS

Burst tank floods the plant room at 23:00

WHERE IT GOES WRONG

Power, lift and warden call fail together. Some residents use powered medical equipment.

HOW IT IS MONITORED

Acknowledgement by flat; anyone silent after 15 minutes gets a call or a visit.

WHO DECIDES

The duty manager sets SEV 2, calls the welfare lead, contractor and power network operator.

THE PROOF

Log shows when each resident was reached. Know what fails when the power goes.

OFFICE CAMPUS, 1,200 STAFF

Heating and ventilation settings change overnight

WHERE IT GOES WRONG

BMS setpoints altered remotely; laboratory ventilation off. A quick reset would wipe the evidence.

HOW IT IS MONITORED

Settings recorded before reset and checked hourly. A reset alone is not enough if the device stays exposed.[2]

WHO DECIDES

The head of facilities treats it as tampering, cuts remote access and approves any reset.

THE PROOF

Log and contractor access records shared with security and the insurer.

GENERAL NEEDS TOWER, 18 STOREYS

Both lifts fail on a Friday evening

WHERE IT GOES WRONG

Residents with limited mobility stranded. One is the firefighting lift. By day two it is a welfare issue.

HOW IT IS MONITORED

Daily calls to residents with limited mobility; the contractor's return date tracked as a task.

WHO DECIDES

The building safety lead owns the repair deadline and any notification to the fire service.

THE PROOF

UK: fire service told when the fault ran past 24 hours, and when fixed.[5] Lift checks on record.

OUTSTANDING ACTIONS

The morning after: what is still open

Illustrative: the day after the three-block night incident. Review the board at every handover until each row is done, and escalate anything overdue or blocked.

ACTION	OWNER	DUE	STATUS	HOW IT IS CHECKED
Call every resident on the assistance register	Welfare lead	Day 1, 10:00	DONE	Status recorded for each resident
Written update to all residents of the three blocks	Comms	Day 1, 11:00	DONE	Delivery and acknowledgement by block
Secure plant room evidence and contractor access records	Facilities manager	Day 1, 12:00	DONE	Photos and records attached to the log
Restore power to Block B; test lifts and door entry	Electrical contractor	Day 1, 18:00	IN PROGRESS	Contractor sign-off in the incident record
Temporary heating for residents with medical needs	Housing officer	Day 1, 16:00	OVERDUE	Resident confirms delivery; escalated to duty manager
Make safe any hazard in affected homes within your response clock	Repairs manager	Day 2, 01:40	IN PROGRESS	Investigation and safety work logged per home
Tell the fire service if a firefighting lift is still out	Building safety lead	Day 2, 01:40	OPEN	Notification time recorded
Decide whether the incident must be reported to a regulator	Head of housing	Day 2	OPEN	Decision and reasons logged
Close contractors' remote access to plant controls	Facilities and IT	Day 5	BLOCKED	Awaiting contractor; escalated to head of facilities

> Due times are illustrative. **United Kingdom:** social landlords in England must investigate and make safe emergency hazards within 24 hours of becoming aware, and in high-rise blocks a firefighting lift fault not fixed in 24 hours must be reported to the fire service.[5,17]

PART 03

Reach, record, recover.

How to change course safely, chase silence, work with contractors at night and leave a record you can stand behind.

01 Changing the evacuation strategy

02 When residents do not respond

03 An acknowledgement and follow-up log

04 Who answers at 3am

05 Records you can stand behind

06 Your first week, month and quarter

STRATEGY CHANGE

Changing from stay put to evacuation

The decision belongs to the fire service. Your job is to make it reach every resident within minutes. The Grenfell Tower Inquiry criticised the absence of contingency plans for a full evacuation.[1]

Hear it once, clearly

Agree in advance how the incident commander's decision reaches your duty manager, and who is allowed to trigger the evacuation message.

Send to everyone, on every channel

One pre-approved instruction, by SMS, push and voice, to every resident and visitor on record. Building alarm and voice systems where fitted.

Watch who has not responded

Non-acknowledgements are not silence. Pass the list of flats not reached to the incident commander, floor by floor.

Prioritise those who need help

Residents on the assistance register are contacted individually and their status reported, using the information already shared with consent.

Log the change

Time of decision, time of message, numbers reached and not reached. This is the record an inquiry, regulator or court will ask for.

Test the strategy-change message at least once a year, alongside the fire safety instructions you give residents.

NON-RESPONDERS

When residents do not acknowledge

Silence is not safety. Illustrative timings for a SEV 1 incident: set your own in the plan and agree with the fire service what they need from you, and when.

TIME	WHAT HAPPENS	OWNER
T+0	First message on at least two channels, in the resident's recorded language where possible.	Duty manager
T+5 min	Resend to everyone not yet acknowledged, under the rules set in the plan. Voice call at once to residents on the assistance register.	Duty manager monitors
T+10 min	Voice call to every remaining non-responder. Message the carer or named contact if one is recorded.	Welfare lead
T+15 min	List of flats not reached, by block and floor, to staff on site. Door-knocking only where safe and agreed with the fire service.	Caretaker or concierge
T+20 min	Flats still not reached, and any register resident not confirmed, passed to the incident commander.	Building safety lead
Until stand-down	Each flat marked reached, visited, passed to the fire service or confirmed away. Nobody leaves the list by assumption.	Welfare lead

TEMPLATE

Acknowledgement and follow-up log

For the duty manager and welfare lead during an incident: every flat that has not acknowledged, what was tried next and how it ended. Keep a printed copy for when power or systems fail.

TIME SENT	BLOCK AND FLAT	CHANNEL	ACKNOW-LEDGED	IF NOT: NEXT STEP AND TIME	DONE BY	OUTCOME
02:12	*B, 9.04*	*SMS and push*	*No*	*Voice call 02:17; door-knock 02:30*	*Caretaker*	*Reached 02:31; staying in flat with door shut*

Illustrative example row. Record the outcome for every flat, including those confirmed away from home, so the list passed to the fire service is accurate.

OUT OF HOURS

Who answers at 3am: five arrangements to settle now

Most building emergencies start outside office hours. The weakest link is usually the hand-off between your on-call team and a contractor's.

01 One number, one owner

A single out-of-hours route, a named duty manager and a deputy who is alerted if the first does not respond within the time you set.

02 Contractor contacts that work

Named 24/7 contacts for alarm, lift, BMS, gas, electrical and water contractors, tested quarterly.

03 Remote access rules

No remote changes during an incident without approval. Remote access only through secured connections.[2,3]

04 Information to hand

Floor plans and the consented list of residents who need help, available away from the office.

05 Who reports to whom

Who tells the fire service, the authorities and insurers, and who decides whether a regulator must be told. **UK:** safety occurrences in higher-risk buildings go to the Building Safety Regulator.[8]

RECORDS

Records you can stand behind

Residents, ombudsmen and regulators increasingly expect a written account. UK: social landlords must give tenants written findings and progress updates on hazards.[17]

AREA	WHAT OFTEN HAPPENS	WHAT GOOD LOOKS LIKE
Timing	Times reconstructed from memory and phone records days later.	Every alert, call and decision timestamped as it happens.
Who was told	"We messaged the residents" with no list.	Recipients, channel, delivery and acknowledgement for every message.
Decisions	Actions recorded, reasons lost.	What was known, what was decided, by whom and why, in the Incident decision log.
Vulnerable residents	A spreadsheet checked if someone remembers.	Each person's status recorded: reached, visited, passed to the fire service.
Contractors	Calls on personal phones, not recorded.	Who was called, when they arrived, what they changed.
Afterwards	A report written from scattered emails.	A timeline ready for the debrief, an ombudsman or the regulator.

YOUR PLAN

Your first week, month and quarter

Owners are suggestions. Adjust them to your structure and building portfolio.

WHEN	ACTIONS	OWNER
First week	Check every out-of-hours contact and escalation route. Confirm contractors' 24/7 numbers. Find any BMS, lift or plant controller reachable from the internet.	Duty manager rota lead
First week	Draft and approve the Communication templates. Confirm who may send an evacuation message.	Head of housing or facilities
First month	Audit records of residents who may need help: consent, contact preference, flat and floor. Confirm what the fire service holds.	Building safety lead
First month	Remove internet exposure of building controls, change default passwords and agree remote access rules with contractors.	Facilities and IT
First month	List the fire, building and housing duties for each building by country and city, using the regional notes as a starting point.	Compliance lead
First quarter	Run the Tabletop exercise, including a strategy change and a BMS fault. Measure time to reach every resident.	Building safety lead
First quarter	Review response clocks, the Incident decision log and resident engagement arrangements. Report to the board.	Director of property

PRACTICAL TOOLKIT

Seven tools for your next incident

The same seven tools appear in every Crises Control playbook, with examples for your industry. Copy them, adapt them and rehearse with them.

01 **Readiness assessment** 27
Score eight areas from 0 to 3 and find your weakest link.

02 **Roles and responsibilities matrix** 28
Who is responsible, accountable, consulted and informed for each activity.

03 **Incident decision log** 29
Record every material decision, who made it and why, as it happens.

04 **Escalation workflow** 30
Four levels, their triggers, who is alerted and who decides.

05 **Communication templates** 31
Ready-to-send messages for staff, customers, regulators, partners and media.

06 **Tabletop exercise** 32
A ready-to-run scenario with timed injects and questions for the room.

07 **Post-incident review template** 33
Eight prompts that turn an incident into lessons and owned actions.

> Every tool works on paper. In Crises Control the same roles, escalation rules, templates and logs can be set up in the platform, so they run during the incident and leave a record afterwards.

TOOLKIT 01 · READINESS ASSESSMENT

How ready is your response?

Score each area from 0 (not in place) to 3 (fully in place) for your property and housing organisation, then add up the total.

AREA	THE QUESTION	SCORE 0 TO 3
01 · ACTIVATION **Alert**	Can you reach the right people on more than one channel within minutes, day or night? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Residents, staff and contractors reached on several channels, including people without smartphones.	0 1 2 3
02 · ACTIVATION **Acknowledge**	Do you know who has seen the alert, and does silence trigger escalation by rule? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Acknowledgement tracked by block and by flat; vulnerable residents followed up first.	0 1 2 3
03 · COORDINATION **Escalate**	Are escalation paths set by role and time, not by whoever remembers who to call? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Out-of-hours escalation to the duty manager and contractor follows rules set in advance.	0 1 2 3
04 · COORDINATION **Coordinate**	Is there one shared workspace and log for the incident, not scattered calls, chats and inboxes? GOOD LOOKS LIKE One log for the incident, shared by housing, repairs, the fire service liaison and communications.	0 1 2 3
05 · EXECUTION **Execute**	Are your procedures turned into owned tasks with deadlines that someone can track? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Repair, damp and fire safety actions run as tasks with owners and deadlines.	0 1 2 3
06 · EXECUTION **See**	Can leaders see tasks, people, locations and blockers live, without having to ask? GOOD LOOKS LIKE A live view of buildings, residents contacted and jobs outstanding.	0 1 2 3
07 · ASSURANCE **Prove**	Could you produce a timestamped timeline for a regulator, insurer or inquiry within a day? GOOD LOOKS LIKE A defensible, timestamped record of every decision and message.	0 1 2 3
08 · ASSURANCE **Rehearse**	Do you exercise the whole response, not just the call tree, at least once a year? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Night-time scenarios rehearsed, including a change from stay put to evacuation.	0 1 2 3

0 to 8
Alerting only
You can send messages. The response still depends on people and luck.

9 to 16
Coordinating in parts
Some steps work. Gaps appear at night, at scale or when systems fail.

17 to 24
Coordinated and provable
You can run the response and show exactly what happened.

TOOLKIT 02 · ROLES AND RESPONSIBILITIES MATRIX

Who does what in a building emergency

Illustrative, for a landlord or managing agent. One person is accountable for each activity; adapt the roles and keep the matrix with the on-call rota.

ACTIVITY	DUTY MANAGER	BUILDING SAFETY LEAD	HEAD OF HOUSING	WELFARE LEAD	COMMS	CONTRACTORS
Open the incident and set the severity level	A	C	I	I	I	·
Send the first message to residents	A	C	·	I	C	·
Relay a change of evacuation strategy to every resident	A	R	I	I	I	·
Give the fire service plans and the consented assistance list	C	A	·	R	·	·
Reach residents with assistance needs and report each status	I	C	·	A	·	·
Chase residents who have not acknowledged	A	·	·	R	·	I
Call out contractors; approve any remote BMS, lift or alarm change	A	C	·	·	·	R
Arrange a rest centre or temporary accommodation	R	·	A	R	I	·
Issue the holding statement and media updates	C	·	A	·	R	·
Decide whether the incident must be reported to a regulator	I	R	A	·	·	·
Keep the Incident decision log and lead the post-incident review	R	A	I	C	C	C

R Responsible: does the work A Accountable: owns the decision C Consulted I Informed

> The fire service decides the evacuation strategy; this matrix covers how you carry it out. Statutory duty-holders keep their legal duties whatever you delegate.

TOOLKIT 03 · INCIDENT DECISION LOG

Every decision on the night, with its reasons

Use it from the first call to stand-down. One line per decision, including decisions not to act, so the post-incident review is built from the log, not from memory.

TIME	DECISION	OPTIONS CONSIDERED	DECIDED BY	RATIONALE	EVIDENCE OR REFERENCE
02:21	*Send the evacuation message to Block B only; Blocks A and C stay put*	*One message to all three blocks; Block B only; wait for further fire service instruction*	*Duty manager (incident lead)*	*Incident commander ordered Block B out at 02:20; one message for all blocks would move A and C residents into smoke-free stairs unnecessarily*	*Fire service instruction 02:20; message log ref B-EVAC-01*

Log decisions as they are made, not afterwards. Include decisions not to act. The log is the backbone of the timeline your board, auditors and regulators will ask for.

TOOLKIT 04 · ESCALATION WORKFLOW

Who is alerted, who decides, and when it goes up

An illustrative route tied to the severity ladder. Each level names a decision owner, so nobody at 3am waits for permission that is not coming.

	TRIGGER	WHO IS ALERTED	WHO DECIDES
LEVEL 1 **Building report**	A caretaker, concierge, resident or BMS alarm reports a fault or hazard. Usually SEV 4 or 3.	Out-of-hours line and building team; the contractor if a repair is needed.	Duty manager on call, who sets the severity level.
↓ ESCALATE IF NOT ACKNOWLEDGED IN 10 MINUTES, OR RESIDENTS' SAFETY MAY BE AFFECTED			
LEVEL 2 **Duty manager**	SEV 2: firefighting lift out, heating lost in cold weather, flood near electrics, unexplained BMS changes.	Duty manager, building safety lead, contractor, residents of affected floors, welfare lead.	Duty manager, with the building safety lead.
↓ ESCALATE IF LIFE IS AT RISK, SEVERAL BLOCKS ARE AFFECTED, OR RESIDENTS MUST LEAVE			
LEVEL 3 **Incident control**	SEV 1: fire, gas escape, people trapped, a change to evacuation, or several blocks affected at once.	Incident lead, head of housing or facilities, every affected resident, communications, fire service liaison.	Incident lead. The fire service decides the evacuation strategy.
↓ ESCALATE IF A REST CENTRE IS NEEDED, SOMEONE IS BADLY HURT, OR THE MEDIA CALL			
LEVEL 4 **Executive**	A prolonged SEV 1, residents displaced overnight, serious injury, or regulator and media scrutiny.	Executive director, the senior duty-holder for the building, board chair, insurers, local authority emergency planning.	Executive director, who also owns reports to regulators.

Escalation is triggered by conditions, not by someone remembering to call. If a level has not acknowledged within its time limit, the next level is alerted under the rules you have set, and the delay is recorded.

TOOLKIT 05 · COMMUNICATION TEMPLATES

Six messages to approve before you need them

Short, specific and written for the person reading at 2am. Keep SMS under 160 characters, send the same instruction on every channel, and put your local emergency number where shown.

SMS · RESIDENTS 148 chars

> FIRE at Lowry House, floor 9. Stay in your flat unless fire or smoke affects it. If it does, get out and call [emergency number]. Updates to follow.

Only while the strategy is stay put.

SMS · RESIDENTS 138 chars

> Lowry House: LEAVE THE BUILDING NOW by the stairs. Do not use lifts. If you cannot get out, call [emergency number] with your flat number.

Strategy change. Voice call anyone who has not acknowledged.

VOICE · RESIDENTS WHO NEED HELP

> This is Northgate Housing. There is a fire at Lowry House. The fire service know you may need help. Keep your front door shut and press 1 to confirm you heard this.

Only say the fire service know if they do.

EMAIL · STAFF AND CONTRACTORS

> Incident at Lowry House from 02:10. On-call staff report to the incident lead. Contractors: make no remote changes to BMS, lift or alarm settings until the duty manager confirms.

Stops resets that destroy evidence.

EMAIL · REGULATOR OR AUTHORITY

> Initial notification: fire at Lowry House reported 02:10. Fire service in attendance; Block B evacuated. Residents displaced: [number]. Next update by [time]. Contact: [duty manager].

Facts only; follow the regulator's own form and deadline.

HOLDING LINE · MEDIA AND FAMILIES

> We are working with the fire service at Lowry House. Residents' safety is our priority. We will update this statement at 04:00.

No speculation on cause or casualties.

TOOLKIT 06 · TABLETOP EXERCISE

Lights out on the estate: a night-time exercise

A night-time scenario across three blocks. Run it in the room or on the platform you would use for real, with the clock running.

DURATION	PARTICIPANTS	OBJECTIVE	FACILITATOR
Two and a half hours, including a 30-minute debrief	**Duty managers, building safety, welfare, comms, a contractor; invite the fire service liaison**	**Reach every resident in three blocks and show who has not responded**	**Someone outside the on-call team, with an observer timing each decision**

01:40	INJECT 1 Calls from Blocks A and C: lights out. A BMS alarm shows high temperature in the shared plant room.	DISCUSS Who opens the incident, and at what level? Is this one incident or three?
01:50	INJECT 2 Smoke reported in Block B's basement. The fire service is on its way. Lifts in all three blocks have stopped.	DISCUSS What does each block hear first, and who approves the wording?
02:05	INJECT 3 The incident commander decides to evacuate Block B. Blocks A and C stay put.	DISCUSS How fast does the change reach every Block B resident without confusing A and C?
02:20	INJECT 4 A third of Block B flats have not acknowledged, including three residents on the assistance register.	DISCUSS Who chases, on which channel? What goes to the incident commander, and when?
02:45	INJECT 5 A contractor offers to reset the plant controls remotely. A local reporter calls the out-of-hours line.	DISCUSS Who decides on remote changes? What is recorded first? Who speaks to the media?
03:30	INJECT 6 Power will not return to Block B tonight. Two residents use powered medical equipment.	DISCUSS Who decides on a rest centre or hotels? How do displaced residents stay informed?

> Measure time to declare, time to first message for each block, time to reach every resident on the assistance register, and how many decisions were logged with reasons. Every gap goes on the actions tracker.

TOOLKIT 07 · POST-INCIDENT REVIEW TEMPLATE

Reviewing a building emergency

Hold the review within two weeks, while memories are fresh, and build it from the Incident decision log rather than recollection. Invite the fire service liaison and a resident representative where appropriate.

INCIDENT _____ DATE _____ SEVERITY _____ REVIEW LEAD _____

01 What happened

Timeline from first report to stand-down, block by block, taken from the log.

02 Who was reached, and how fast

Residents messaged, acknowledged and not reached, by block and channel.

03 Residents who need help

Was everyone on the assistance register reached or reported? Anyone missing from it?

04 Decisions and who made them

Severity, strategy change, rest centre, remote changes: who, when, on what information.

05 Where it went wrong

Delays, missed hand-offs, confusing messages, gaps out of hours or with contractors.

06 Contractors and building systems

Who attended, what they changed, and whether settings were recorded before any reset.

07 Duties and reports

Fire service notifications, response clocks for hazards, and any report owed to a regulator.

08 Actions, owners, dates

Each lesson becomes a tracked action with an owner, a due date and a check.

FOR LEADERS

Questions for your leadership team

Ask them out loud. Vague answers are the finding.

REACH

? If we had to evacuate our tallest building tonight, how long would it take to reach every resident, and how would we know who we had missed?

? Do we know, for every building, which residents need help to leave, and does the fire service have that information with their consent?

? Who decides, at 3am, that an incident is SEV 1?

CONTROL AND PROOF

? Which of our building systems can be reached from the internet, and who can change them?

? Could we produce a timed record of every message and decision from our last incident within a day?

? Do we know which fire, housing and workplace rules apply to each building, and are we meeting their timescales?

CHECKLIST

Can you reach every resident?

Tick what is true today. Anything blank is your next action.

- [ ] **One out-of-hours route with escalation rules**
  Tested in the last three months.

- [ ] **Approved Communication templates**
  Including a stay put to evacuation change and a holding line.

- [ ] **Consented records of residents who need help**
  With flat, floor, contact preference and review date.

- [ ] **Fire safety instructions issued to every resident**
  On arrival and at regular intervals. **UK:** every 12 months in blocks of flats.[5]

- [ ] **Contractor 24/7 contacts and remote access rules**
  No exposed controllers, no default passwords.

- [ ] **A clock for hazards in homes**
  Set by your local rules. **UK:** social landlords have 24 hours for emergency hazards.[17,18]

- [ ] **Incident decision log in use**
  Every incident, timestamped, with recipients and acknowledgements.

- [ ] **Night-time exercise in the last year**
  Including vulnerable residents and a strategy change.

GLOSSARY

Words worth knowing

Stay put
A strategy in which residents not affected by fire or smoke remain in their homes, relying on fire-resisting construction.

Simultaneous evacuation
Everyone leaves at once when the alarm sounds or when told to.

Assistance register
A consented list of residents who may need help to leave or to stay safe, with contact preferences.

Emergency action plan
US: the plan an employer must have where an OSHA standard requires one.[10]

Life Safety Code
US: NFPA 101, a model code that applies where a state or local jurisdiction adopts it.[9]

Responsible person
UK: the person with fire safety duties for the common parts of a building, usually the landlord or managing agent.[5]

Higher-risk building
UK: in occupation, a building at least 18 metres or seven storeys tall with at least two residential units.

Residential PEEP
UK: a personal emergency evacuation plan for a resident who cannot evacuate unaided.[6]

Emergency hazard
UK: under Awaab's Law, a hazard posing an imminent and significant risk of harm that must be made safe within 24 hours.[17]

BMS
Building management system: the controls that run heating, ventilation, lighting, pumps and sometimes access and lifts.

WHY COORDINATION, NOT JUST NOTIFICATION

Most organisations can send alerts. Few can manage incidents end-to-end.

When a fire alarm sounds in a high-rise at 02:10, a text to residents is minute one. Keeping everyone safe depends on which residents need help, which contractor is on the way, who changed the evacuation strategy, and a record you can stand behind later.

WHERE INCIDENTS GO WRONG

01	**Fragmented information**	Different teams work from different information.
02	**Delayed decision making**	Leadership lacks visibility, so decisions wait.
03	**Uncoordinated response**	Several teams work independently on the same problem.
04	**Lack of visibility**	Critical actions become difficult to track.
05	**Lack of accountability**	Actions and decisions are poorly documented.

THE WHOLE INCIDENT, IN ONE PLATFORM



Crises Control is an **Operational Incident Coordination Platform**. It helps organisations maintain operational control during incidents by combining alerting, coordination, execution, visibility and accountability in one platform.

THE PLATFORM

One connected platform, from first alert to final report.

Most organisations can send alerts. Few can manage incidents end-to-end. Crises Control helps organisations maintain operational control during incidents by combining alerting, coordination, execution, visibility and accountability in one platform. Each module of this incident management software does one job; the value comes from how they work together across the incident.

01

ESCALATE

SOS

Frontline staff raise an alert from the mobile app, with location where available.

02

START

Ping

Alerting and activation: reach people and collect acknowledgements and responses.

03

COORDINATE

Incident Manager

Authorised users activate the incident and its response plan, assign roles, control communication and keep the timeline.

04

EXECUTE

Task Manager

Assign actions, track completion and escalate what stalls, with clear accountability.

05

OPERATE

Control Centre

Real-time view of incidents, timelines, task status and assets.

06

PROVE

Audit & Reporting

Incident records, response analysis and task accountability, ready to report.

07

ASSIST

CRAiG

AI assistant (beta) that answers questions and summarises incident data. People make every decision.

THE OUTCOMES

Alerting and activation

Reach the right people immediately.

Operational coordination

Structure communication and response activities.

Execution and visibility

Track tasks, responsibilities and progress.

Proof and accountability

Create a complete, defensible operational record.

Most organisations start with the capability they need today, often alerting, and expand as their requirements mature. Highlighted modules are the ones this playbook draws on.

HOW THE MODULES WORK TOGETHER

How an Operational Incident Coordination Platform works in a building emergency

The three-block night incident from this playbook, followed through Crises Control from the first report to the record you hand the review.

01	ESCALATE **SOS**	A concierge or caretaker raises an incident with a press-and-hold SOS alert, sharing their location where available.
02	START **Ping**	Residents in the affected blocks get the stay-put or evacuation message by SMS, voice and push; those who do not acknowledge are re-alerted under the rules you configure.
03	COORDINATE **Incident Manager**	The duty manager opens one incident across all three blocks, assigns roles and logs the fire service's strategy decision.
04	EXECUTE **Task Manager**	Welfare calls, door-knocks and contractor call-outs become owned tasks with deadlines, assigned when the plan is activated.
05	OPERATE **Control Centre**	The incident lead sees who has acknowledged, by the groups set up for each block, which tasks are open and what has escalated.
06	PROVE **Audit & Reporting**	A timestamped record of every message, acknowledgement and decision logged, exportable for the review, an ombudsman or the regulator.
07	ASSIST **CRAiG**	Users ask CRAiG (beta) questions about the incident data they can see, such as which flats have not yet responded.

COORDINATION
Everyone works from the same incident, roles and log.

VISIBILITY
Leaders see progress without chasing for updates.

EXECUTION
Every action has an owner, a deadline and an escalation.

ACCOUNTABILITY
The record of what happened builds itself as you go.

WHAT IS STANDARD, WHAT IS CONFIGURED

Clear about what the platform does.

Some capabilities work as standard. Others depend on how your team sets up plans, groups and rules, or on connecting your own systems. Your demonstration and implementation plan confirm what applies to you.

STANDARD

Included in how each module works.

- SOS press-and-hold alert from the mobile app, raising an incident and sharing location where available
- Ping alerts by push, SMS, voice, email and desktop, with one-tap acknowledgement
- Incident Manager workspace, roles and a single communication log
- Task Manager tasks with owners and deadlines when a plan is activated
- Control Centre live view of status, acknowledgements, tasks and locations
- Audit & Reporting: timestamped records, exportable as PDF or CSV
- CRAiG (beta): answers questions and summarises your incident data within each user's permissions

CONFIGURED

Set up by your team to match your plans.

- Response plans, task lists and message templates per incident type
- Groups, sites and audiences to target
- Escalation rules and timings when people do not respond
- Cascading from one channel to the next
- Response options people can choose when they acknowledge

INTEGRATIONS

Connected to your other systems, where configured.

- Directory sync with Microsoft Entra ID, SCIM or scheduled file import
- Single sign-on with Entra ID, Google Workspace or Okta
- The Microsoft Teams app, enabled by your administrator
- Triggers from monitoring or other systems, set up as an integration project

> Crises Control does not detect incidents on its own. Incidents are raised by people, through SOS, the app or the web, or by connected systems where an integration has been configured. From that point the platform coordinates the response.

USE CASES

How organisations use Crises Control in property, housing and facilities

From the first alert to the final record: the incidents this platform is used for, and how the modules work together in each.

Resident emergency communication

INTENDED USE

TRIGGER Fire, evacuation, flooding, gas incident or another building emergency

Notify residents and building teams, provide instructions and updates, and use responses to identify who has acknowledged or needs follow-up.

Ping | Incident Manager | two-way response | Control Centre

Multi-building incident management

SUGGESTED APPLICATION

TRIGGER An incident affects several buildings or properties in a managed portfolio

Target communications to affected properties, coordinate local building teams and contractors, and maintain a consolidated view of response activity.

Ping | Incident Manager | Task Manager | Control Centre | Audit & Reporting

Resident welfare and assistance checks

SUGGESTED APPLICATION

TRIGGER An incident affects residents who may need additional help or have not responded

Collect resident status responses, identify outstanding acknowledgements and direct follow-up to the appropriate building or welfare team.

Ping | Incident Manager | Control Centre | Task Manager

Out-of-hours incident response

SUGGESTED APPLICATION

TRIGGER An overnight or weekend emergency requires on-call managers or contractors

Alert the on-call response group, track acknowledgement, escalate non-response and coordinate actions until the incident is resolved.

Ping | Incident Manager | Task Manager | Control Centre

Contractor and facilities coordination

SUGGESTED APPLICATION

TRIGGER Lift failure, water leak, power outage, heating failure or urgent repair

Notify facilities teams and contractors, assign inspection and repair tasks, set owners and deadlines, and monitor completion.

Ping | Incident Manager | Task Manager | Control Centre | Audit & Reporting

Customer examples are based on how customers use Crises Control today; customer names have been removed. Customer requirements describe needs raised by customers or in evaluations. Intended, suggested and illustrative use cases show how the platform can be applied and are not presented as existing customer deployments. Capabilities marked 'where configured' or 'where available' depend on each organisation's set-up.

BUYER'S GUIDE

Eight questions to ask any incident platform supplier

Many tools can send an alert. These questions separate a notification tool from a platform that coordinates the whole response.

01 **Does it stop at the message?**
Ask what the platform does after the alert is sent: tasks, log, escalation, recovery.

02 **Can it prove who acknowledged?**
Delivery is not acknowledgement. Ask how silence is spotted and escalated, and what you must configure.

03 **Does it run your procedures?**
Ask whether your plans become owned tasks with deadlines, or stay as documents.

04 **Is there one shared picture?**
Ask what leaders see live, and whether it needs someone to update a spreadsheet.

05 **Does it work when your systems do not?**
Ask how teams coordinate if email, chat or your network is down.

06 **Can frontline staff raise the alarm?**
Ask how a colleague on site escalates, with their location where available, in one action.

07 **What evidence does it leave behind?**
Ask for a sample timeline of the kind a regulator, insurer or inquiry would want.

08 **Can you rehearse in it?**
Ask whether you can run exercises on the same platform you would use for real.

SOURCES

Sources and notes

Sources were accessed in November 2026. Legal duties are summarised for orientation, not legal advice; read the regulations and official guidance for the full requirements. Building and organisation names in the examples are fictional. Last reviewed: November 2026.

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20 Directive (EU) 2018/1972 (European Electronic Communications Code), Article 110, public warning systems

BOOK YOUR PROPERTY, HOUSING AND FACILITIES PLATFORM DEMONSTRATION

Watch a night-time fire run end to end.

Most organisations can send alerts. Few can manage incidents end-to-end. In a live, 30-minute demonstration built around a property, housing and facilities incident, you will see how our incident management software, an Operational Incident Coordination Platform, takes one incident from first alert to final report. Bring your own scenario.

WHAT YOU WILL SEE

01	SOS	A concierge raises a fire alarm alert from the building, with location where available.
02	PING	Residents, the duty manager and contractors are alerted; acknowledgements come back by flat.
03	INCIDENT MANAGER	The incident is activated, roles assigned and the evacuation decision logged.
04	TASK MANAGER	Welfare checks for residents with assistance needs become owned tasks.
05	CONTROL CENTRE	The duty manager sees buildings, residents reached and jobs outstanding.
06	AUDIT & REPORTING	A defensible record of every message and decision is produced.
07	CRAIG	CRAiG helps the duty manager find information in the platform and summarise the incident so far.

Book your demonstration →

crises-control.com/property-management-incident-management-software/

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SCAN TO BOOK

COMPANION REPORT Safe homes, clear duties